

Though we'd been with Mr. Bermont only a few months before I began preparing for this journey, he'd done a fairly good job investing for my wife. In fact, he'd made her some money. Perhaps I should explain why I didn't mention this earlier. To me, it was an extraordinary aberration, and so I dismissed it as freak behavior. By now, I had little to do with the remains of her portfolio.

It would have been simple—and perhaps wise—to have transferred my own capital, plus accrued interest, into a new account at Drexel and to have worked with Mr. Bermont on this project for the rest of the way. But that seemed too easy. Besides, I was determined to make a careful and well-informed choice of my personal broker—which is not the way we'd engaged him.

I never mentioned any of this to Mr. Bermont, and I hoped the news of my searching around for yet another broker would never get back to him. As quietly as possible, I made the local rounds.

My first stop was the local Thomson McKinnon, where the front door opened into a small amphitheater. An audience of senior citizens stared skyward, moving their heads in unison as if following a slow-moving skeet. Instead, they were watching a ticker tape with huge electronic letters. As various stock symbols passed by, I heard one man mutter, "Look at that IBM. I used to own it, but then my wife said, 'Let's get rid of it, it isn't going nowhere,' so I get rid of it and it splits and splits and goes to \$150." Then I heard another say: "Schlumberger? Down to \$40? I fell in love with that stock back in the '70s, when I should have kicked it out." This was an average investor's *This Is Your Life*, which continues day after day. I wished I'd had more time to sit down and watch the old-timers review their existence, as each SB, KO, or XON seemed to bring back memories.

At the side of the theater sat a secretary. I asked her if I could see someone in charge. "That would be our broker of the day," she said. She explained that the broker of the day is the person who gets all the walk-in business.

I was ushered back through carpeted hives where 30 or more brokers were separated by the semiprivacy of half-walls. A cirrus of cigar smoke rose above them. The secretary deposited me at the edge of the rearmost cubicle, and a young man motioned me